

Describing trends

Teaching guide

Describe a change with its amount and time period.

Understand the distinction

Use rise, increase, fall, or decrease for direction. Use remain stable for little change and fluctuate for repeated movement up and down. A number without a time period or unit can be misleading.

Distinguish rise by from rise to: from 40 to 50 is a rise by 10, ending at 50. A change from 20% to 25% is five percentage points, or a 25% relative increase. Describe the data separately from an explanation of its cause.

Compare the patterns

START AND END

Attendance rose from 40 to 50 in June.

The unit is people; the period is June.

AMOUNT

Attendance rose by 10.

By introduces the size of the change.

LIMIT

The figures rose, but the cause is unclear.

The trend alone does not establish a cause.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Attendance rose from 20 to 30. How much did it rise by?

2. Correct the preposition: Sales rose by 500 to 600.

3. A rate rises from 10% to 12%. How many percentage points is that?

Use it in your own life

Describe a fictional trend with a unit, period, and no unsupported cause.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. 10 people

Subtract the starting count from the ending count.

2. Sales rose from 500 to 600.

From and to give the starting and ending values.

3. 2 percentage points

Subtract the percentages; the relative increase is 20%.

One possible response

Bus use rose from 80 to 100 journeys per day in July. The reason is not yet clear.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-43.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe a fictional trend with a unit, period, and no unsupported cause.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.